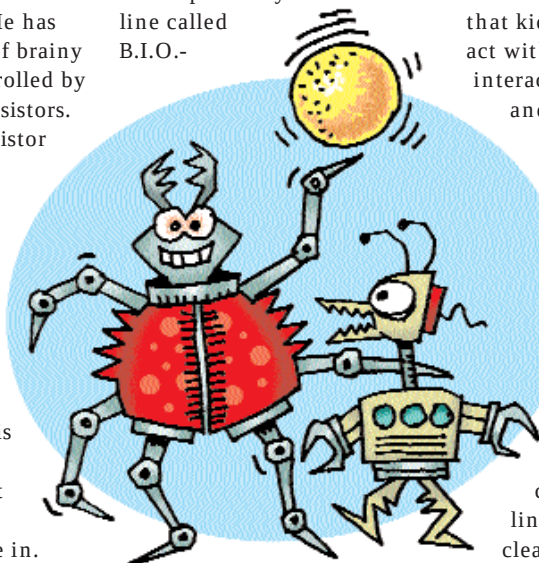


A bug's life?

Do robots really need computers inside them? Mark Tilden of Los Alamos says no. He has just created a bunch of brainy 'bugs' which are controlled by a combination of transistors. By changing the transistor combinations, the behaviour of the bugs can be changed as the user wants it to behave.

The speciality of Tilden's bugs is that they can be trained. A technique called biomorphic robotics is used inside the bugs, making them interact and learn with the environment they are in.

The toy giant Hasbro attracted by this feature, developed a toy line called B.I.O.-



Bugs, which is inspired by Tilden's work. The USP behind this range of toys is that kids can actually interact with them. The bugs can interact with each other too, and what's more, if a kid gets bored with the robots' behaviour, all he or she needs to do is change the combinations to make the bug behave in the desired manner.

If you think this is neat, just wait till Tilden comes out with his line of robotic vacuum cleaners!

Backdoor man

If you think all that music you've been downloading from the Web is absolutely free with no strings attached, think again! It has been discovered that things are not so hunky-dory with file sharing programs. These file-sharing programs open your PC to anyone on the Net, specially making it vulnerable due to the spyware used in them.



Experts have found that



popular fire sharing programs such as Limewire and Grokster carry spyware. Spyware in advertising software such as 'Clicktilluwin'

has programs such as W32.DIDder, which is classified by Symantec as a Trojan horse. Trojan horses allow other people to take over your PC and do whatever they want to. There are reports of similar problems with the KaZaA Media Desktop as well.

Limewire and Grokster have removed or provided fixes to remove the programs. But it remains to be seen as to what they will come up with next to get hold of your PC again. As for now, trust a good anti virus program to protect you while using all these file-sharing programs. After all, there's no such thing as a free lunch, right?

A lobster's sniff

Science has always sought inspiration from the master of design—nature. The University of Colorado is also taking the same route in an attempt to develop teams of 'sniffer' robots to sniff out mines. Lobsters have an exceptional ability to analyse odours.

The research is aimed at developing a team of sniffer robots to be used on land and sea to detect mines. These robots will have artificial snouts based on the lobster's skills. Odours are carried downstream or along the wind by chemical plumes. Lobsters are wizards at tracing these plumes to the source, even in troubled waters.

Mass produced mines leak TNT. This leakage can be used to trace the mines.

redalert

Suffer this Trojan

This Trojan's sure going to make you suffer if you get it. If you run this Trojan, it displays a black box with the word 'suffer...' flashing in it. Each time it flashes, your PC's CD-ROM drive will open and close. Placing the mouse pointer over the window gives a message saying, 'you've been caught slippin'. It also swaps mouse buttons, changes your PC's name to a rude one, disables the [Ctrl] + [Alt] + [Del] combination, etc. The Trojan degrades system performance. And you will most probably require a cold reboot, since the system will stop responding.

Trojan Tux

RST.b is a remote shell Trojan (RST) which attacks Linux machines. This is a variant of the RST Trojan, discovered last September.

RST.b creates a backdoor on the computers it infects. Remote attackers can get full control of the computer through this backdoor. It also connects to the remote server and tries to retrieve a file located there. This file has the message, 'This account has been terminated for virus abuse. We are a free Web hosting company and anyone may post or create PHP files. This machine has NOT been compromised.'

The Trojan's code contains self-replicating capabilities. This allows the Trojan to replicate itself to other binary files on the PC like a virus. However, there is lesser risk than on other OSs since Linux has defined access privileges for each user and it can only infect that particular user's access areas.